final report

# Certificates Baseline vs. Premium Tiers Conjoint Study Results

August 2025

## Background & Objective:

Research Plan: Certs Premium Features / Upsell - Research Plan
Understand 1) baseline pricing parameters by subject 2) premium tier pricing by subject.

## Executive Summary:

*General caveat: this is a signal from a survey where respondents are recruited as highly engaged, career motivated individuals and they are not spending actual money! People in the real world may / will act differently especially when it comes to actually spending so would take this analysis as directional signals.*

| Section | Recommendation |
|---|---|
| 1. Baseline pricing and Premium pricing | The directional signal from the conjoint indicates we could price up to $399 for baseline for NSF and up to $699 for premium. |
| 2. Baseline pricing by subject | Baseline prices we could test for NVIDIA and MSFT could be up to $599 and NSF and GMS could be up to $499. *Please review caveats in the full report.* |
| 3. Attributes that influence preference / price | Attributes that influence preference / price most should be what we considering building into a future premium tier: Expert access (13%), Coaching (12%), Networking (11%) |
| 4. Desirability of Levels within Each Attribute | Within attributes, AI coaches, Slack Community, and any of the Expert Access options (would recommend choosing lowest lift) would drive an appealing Premium tier. |
| 5. Ideal premium tier for the future | If we include ALL of the best premium levels per attribute, we could potentially charge up to $899 for a premium tier. Of course we'd need to consider execution / cost implications.<br><br>From a priority standpoint, at minimum, would include:<br>Expert Access: AI Teaching Assistant or Live Monthly Office Hours (+10 points on preference)<br>Networking: Slack Community (+9 points on preference)<br>Coaching: AI Coaches (+9 points on preference)<br>Practice: Roleplay (+5 points only but easy to include since we already have it)<br><br>Potential to deprioritize:<br>Personalization: Goal Tracking Dashboard (+5 points only; could remodel if we want to drop this due to lift and/or if we feel baseline is personalized enough)<br>Interviewing: Guaranteed Interview at Fortune 500 company (+3 points only; more relevant for |

| | |
|---|---|
| | MSFT of all subjects) |
| 6. Subject bundling and overlaps | Once we have the scale, offer subscription for multi subject access. Prior to that, similar subjects like MSFT and NVIDIA could be bundled effectively. Would not bundle NSF and GSM. |

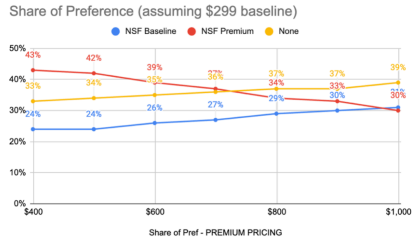
# Full Report:

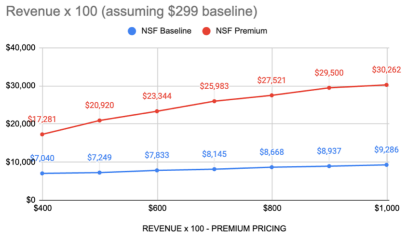
## 1. Baseline pricing + premium pricing (current situation: NSF)

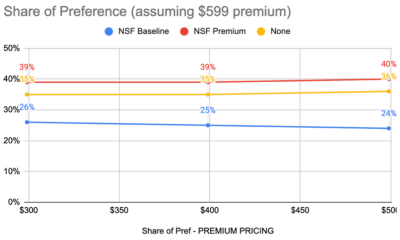
a. **Recommendation**: **The directional signal from the conjoint indicates we could price up to $399 for baseline for NSF and up to $699 for premium.**

b. *Based on our current premium solution and assuming they can only purchase NSF to start (note that we did NOT have lifetime access or credits built into the study so that is not accounted for). This premium solution assumes: AI coaching and AI roleplay.*

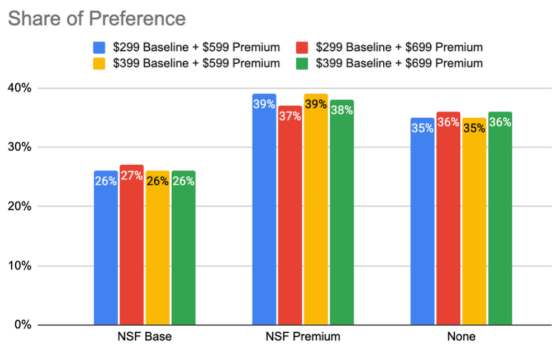
c. We first assessed ideal rough price points for baseline and premium for NSF to establish parameters for pricing. **This analysis indicated $299 - $399 for baseline and $599 - $699 for premium:**

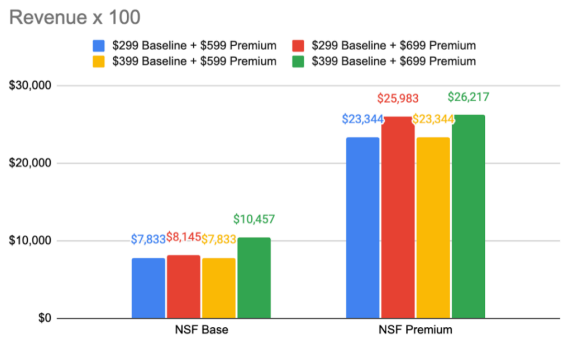


d. Comparing these options, the **$399 baseline and $699 premium seem like better options for maximizing revenue with minimal preference drop off.**



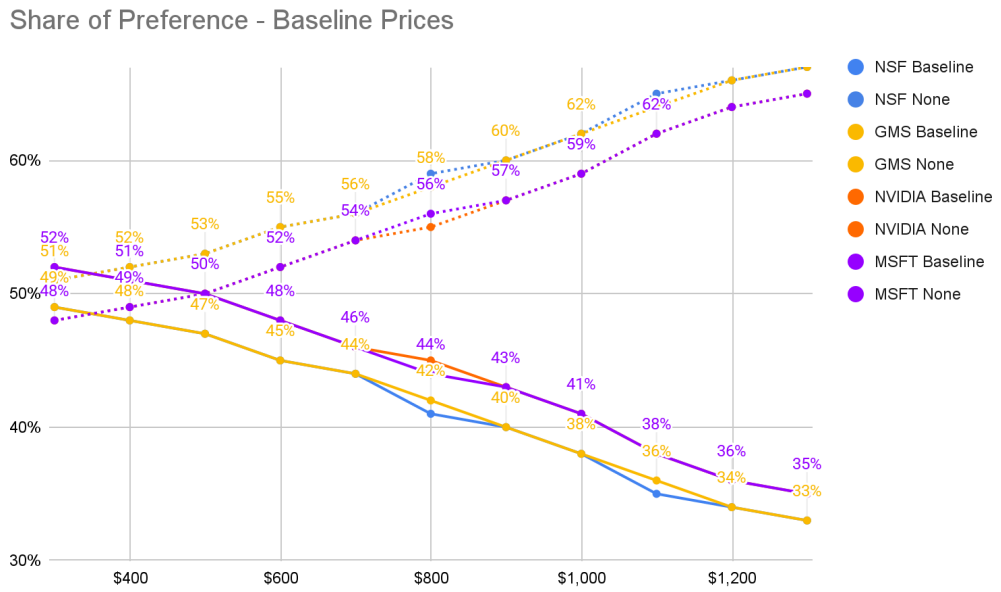



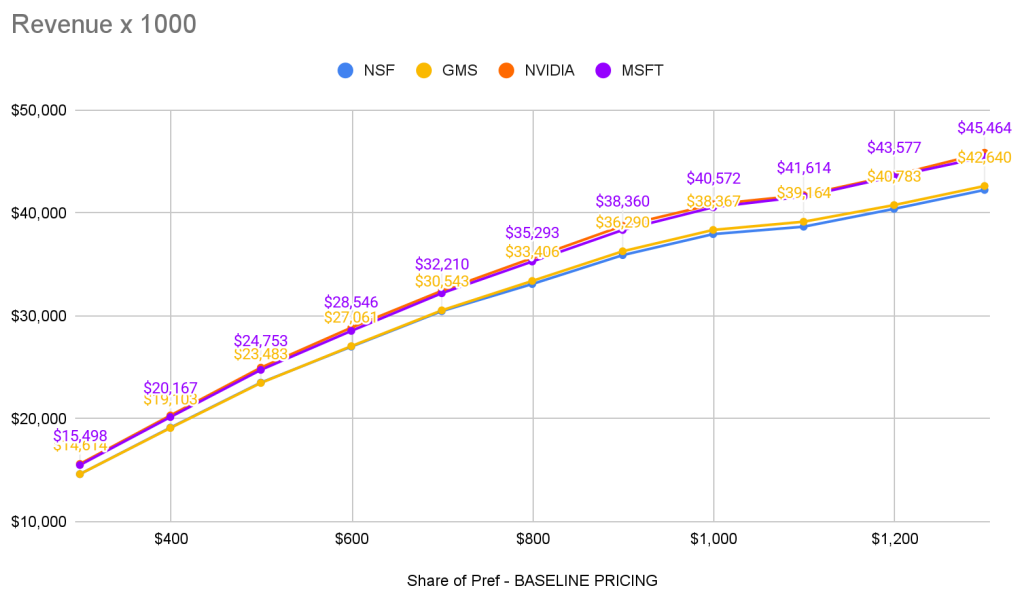

## 2. Baseline pricing by subject

a. **Recommendation: baseline prices we could test for NVIDIA and MSFT could be up to $599 and NSF and GMS could be up to $499.**

b. *Note: this analysis is looking at each subject on its own in isolation to understand true price differentiation of subject; not necessarily in the sequential order that we'd be launching in with other options available and with premium tiers available.*

c. In isolation, NVIDIA and MSFT can charge the highest baseline prices. Potentially from $499 - $599. NSF and GMS you would probably want to max out at $399 - $499.






# 3. Attributes that influence preference / price

a. **Recommendation: Attributes that influence preference / price most should be what we considering building into a future premium tier: Expert access (13%), Coaching (12%), Networking (11%)**
b. Unsurprisingly, price is a key driver of preference when it comes to purchasing a certificate program
c. Subject scores low in driving preference difference, given that the four subjects were all fairly appealing to respondents (high overlap) and in the real world, it's assumed they'd only consider a subject that they'd be interested in
d. Interviewing scores surprisingly low - it did not drive willingness to pay
e. By subject, we see some slight differences although across all, Expert Access, Networking, and Coaching were the highest drivers

| | | | **NSF** | **MOONSHOTS** | **NVIDIA** | **MICROSOFT** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | Total | Subject Interest: Leadership and Decision-Making | Subject Interest: Innovation Strategy | Subject Interest: Scaling AI Strategy | Subject Interest: AI for Teams |
| 1 | Subject | 4% | 3% | 2% | 8% | 6% |
| 2 | Expert Access | 13% | 13% | 13% | 13% | 14% |
| 3 | Interviewing | 5% | 6% | 8% | 8% | 7% |
| 4 | Practice | 9% | 8% | 9% | 8% | 9% |
| 5 | Personalization | 8% | 7% | 8% | 8% | 7% |
| 6 | Networking | 11% | 10% | 11% | 9% | 11% |
| 7 | Coaching | 12% | 14% | 14% | 11% | 13% |

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | Price ($299-$1299) | 37% | 38% | 36% | 35% | 33% |
| | | 100% | 100% | 100% | 100% | 100% |

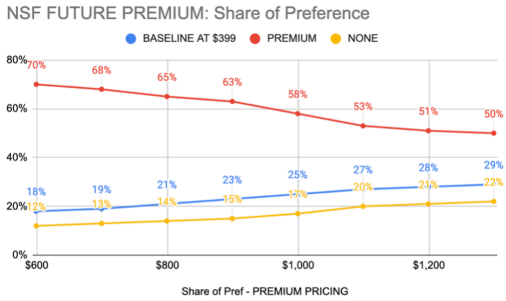
## 4. Desirability of Levels within Each Attribute

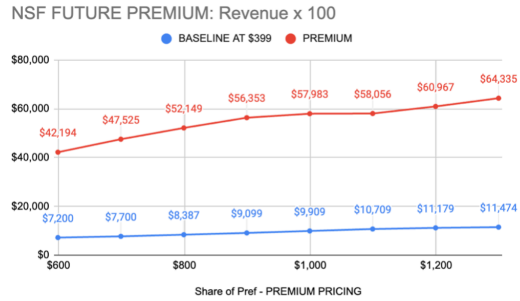
a. **Recommendations: Within attributes, AI coaches, Slack community, and any of the Expert Access options (would recommend choosing lowest lift) would drive an appealing Premium tier.**
b. This allows us to see what levels resonated most for each attribute and how much preference each level drove. Link to spreadsheet here (too big to paste).
c. High level takeaways:
    i. **Coaching**: big lift in pricing and preference. +10 points by adding either AI coaches or certified coaches. Potentially respondents were unclear if 'certified coaches' were human or AI? In past research, we have seen a bigger difference in human vs. AI coaching so something to understand more. But overarching takeaway from this research and past research is that coaching makes an impact.
    ii. **Networking:** Lifts preference by 10 points. Slack community is lower lift than potentially other options and even with just that, drives strong preference increase. Worth exploring more options in Networking as well. We've also heard the important of networking reflected in past research as well.
    iii. **Expert Access**: Expert access makes a difference in pricing, lifting preference by up to +9points! But pick cheapest / lowest lift since preference doesn't differ much between levels offered.
    iv. **Interviewing:** Surprisingly, not a huge driver of preference change. Probably not worth the effort. MAYBE if we can guarantee an interview for Fortune 500 but lift may outweigh revenue benefit. Matters more for NVIDIA and Microsoft.
    v. **Practice**: AI roleplay (On Call) lifts preference by +6points, which is promising to see!
    vi. **Personalization**: Goal setting / tracking dashboard drives a +5pts increase in preference change. Would prioritize this over the other levels shown. Not a major increase from no personalization offered though which may speak to baseline expectation of the program to be personalized enough. Potentially more important to incorporate baseline levels of personalization vs. using it as a draw for premium tier.

# 5. Ideal premium tier (future)

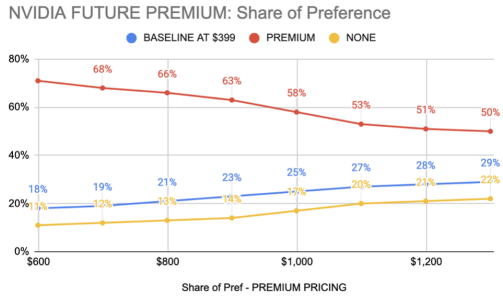
a. **Recommendation: if we include ALL of the best premium levels per attribute, we could potentially charge up to $899 for a premium tier. From a priority standpoint, at minimum, would include:**
   i. **Expert Access: AI Teaching Assistant or Live Monthly Office Hours (+10 points on preference)**
   ii. **Networking: Slack Community (+9 points on preference)**
   iii. **Coaching: AI Coaches (+9 points on preference)**
   iv. **Practice: Roleplay (+5 points only but easy to include since we already have it)**
   v. **Potential to drop:**
      1. **Personalization: Goal Tracking Dashboard (+5 points only; could remodel if we want to drop this)**
      2. **Interviewing: Guaranteed Interview at Fortune 500 company (+3 points only; more relevant for MSFT of all subjects)**

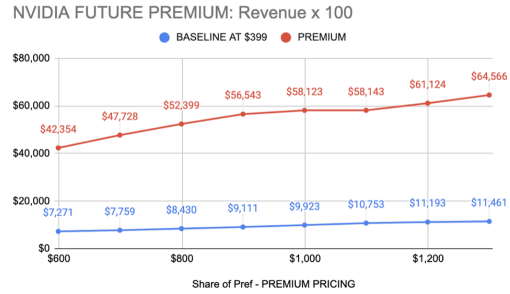
b. If we included all the highest scoring features into NSF, the max we'd want to charge is probably $899 (assuming $399 baseline) before preference jumps down. GSM functions similarly to NSF.




c. We see this similarly to NVIDIA if $399 is the baseline price as well. MSFT functions similarly to NVIDIA.



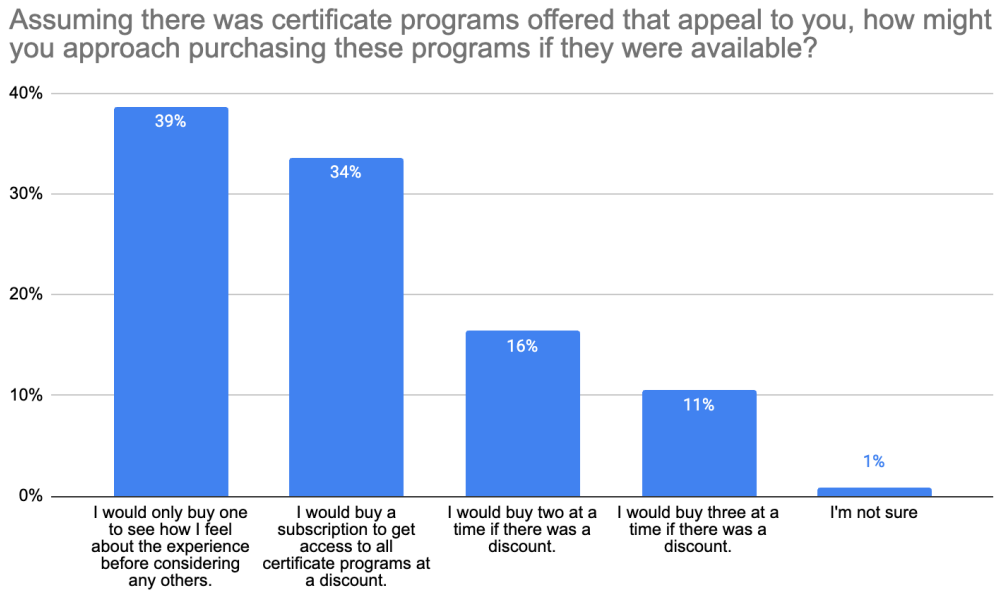

d. We could potentially cut interviewing as it does not have a significant impact on preference and is high execution. Otherwise, the rest of the options do drive minimum 5 points of preference. Note that we selected "*AI Teaching Assistant*" as the lowest lift route of Expert Access, but could swap in with *"Monthly live office hours with a subject matter expert / industry leader"* which would give the same level of preference. The other two options drop preference slightly (email or text a question; 15m live video consult).

| NVIDIA FUTURE PREMIUM PACKAGE EXAMPLE | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **At $899....** | | **Preference** | |
| Expert Access | AI Teaching Assistant | 32% | |
| Practice | + AI Roleplay | 37% | +5 points |
| Networking | + Slack Community | 46% | +9 points |
| Coaching | + AI Coaches | 55% | +9 points |
| Personalization | + Goal Tracking Dashboard | 60% | +5 points |
| Interviewing | + guaranteed interview at Fortune 500 | 63% | + 3 points |

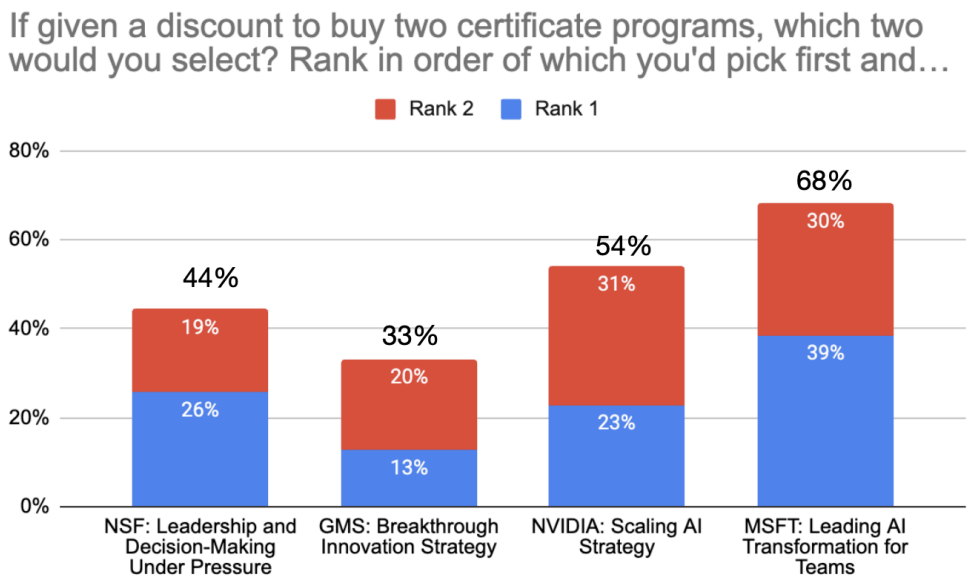
# 6. Subject bundling + overlaps

a. **Recommendation: once we have the scale, offer subscription for cross subject access. Prior to that, similar subjects like MSFT and NVIDIA could be bundled effectively. Would not bundle NSF and GSM.**

b. Initial sense from highly engaged and motivated respondents are that the majority would only buy one at a time (39%). Second most appealing is a subscription service to have access to all of them (34%; note we saw high overlap in subject interest with this group - may not be as high in the real world).




c. Bundling was less appealing (16% for two and 11% for three)
   i. If they were to bundle, MSFT and NVIDIA as a bundle would be most appealing.




d. Overall, interest in classes was highly overlapping particularly amongst **MSFT** and **NVIDIA** and **MSFT** and **GMS**.

i.

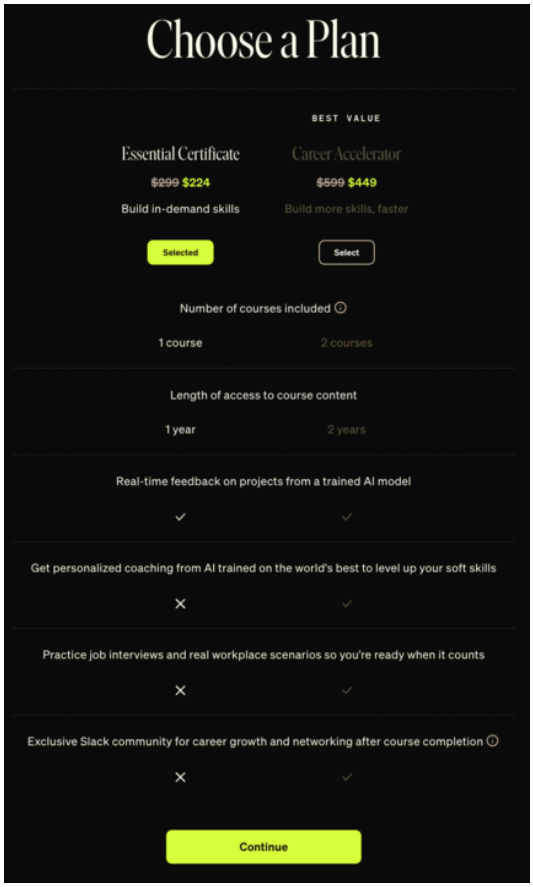
| **Overlap of Class Interest** | NSF: Leadership and Decision-Making Under Pressure | GMS: Breakthrough Innovation Strategy | NVIDIA: Scaling AI Strategy | MSFT: Leading AI Transformation for Teams |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| NSF: Leadership and Decision-Making Under Pressure | 100% | 74% | 72% | 74% |
| GMS: Breakthrough Innovation Strategy | 66% | 100% | 71% | 69% |
| NVIDIA: Scaling AI Strategy | 70% | 77% | 100% | 77% |
| MSFT: Leading AI Transformation for Teams | 79% | 83% | 85% | 100% |

**Notes**

- Proposal: NSF / Moonshots
  - 299 / 599 at launch for NSF / Moonshots, with subsequent 399/699 test post launch
- NVIDIA /Microsoft:
  - What do we launch with for NVIDIA / Msft? What do we test? What is dependent on NSF / Moonshots test results?
    - Simulation of 299/599 and 399/699 nsf/moonshots test
    - If Nvidia / Msft launch w/ base price 599, how does this impact the perception of other Cert products?
- How do we decide if we include a credit in the premium tier given:
  - Price justified by features that dont include credit
  - Credit system is incremental lift operationally and eng-wise

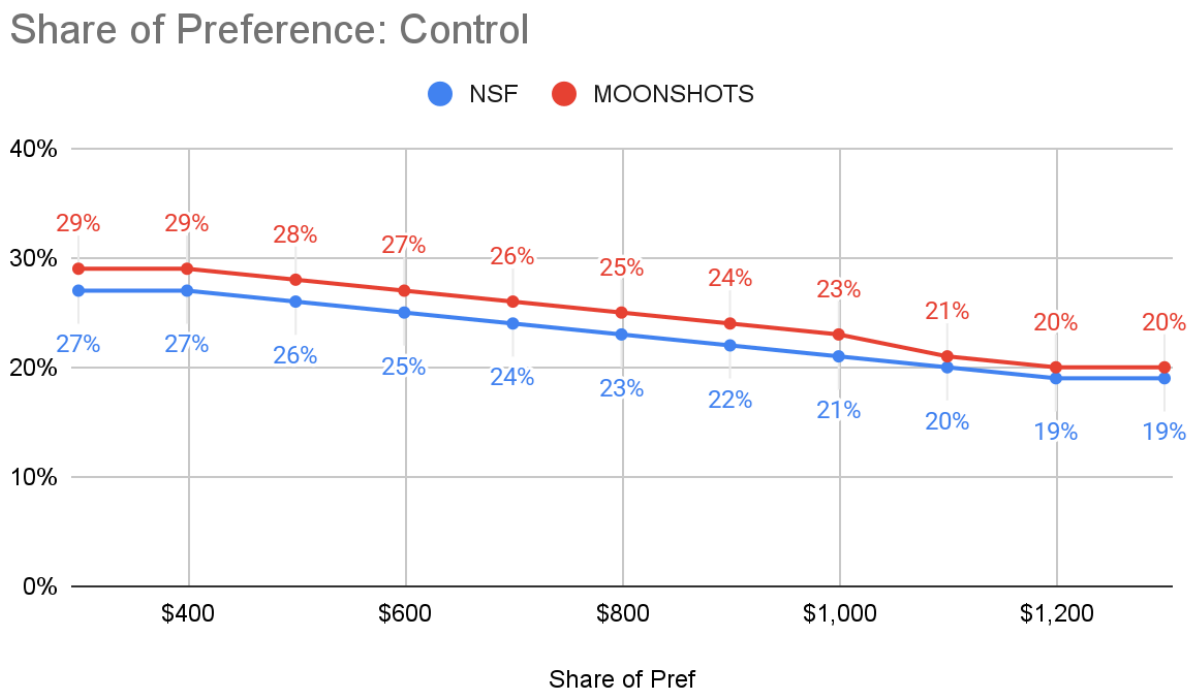
single tier update

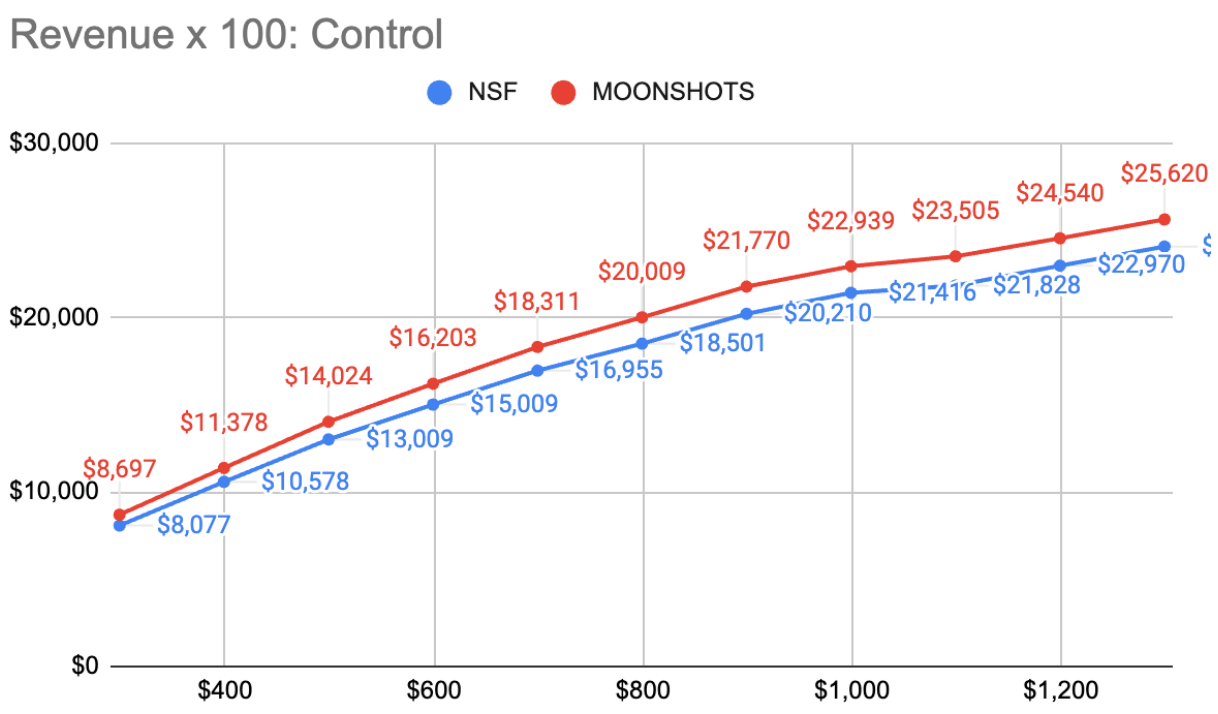
Single Tier Tested:




## Pricing

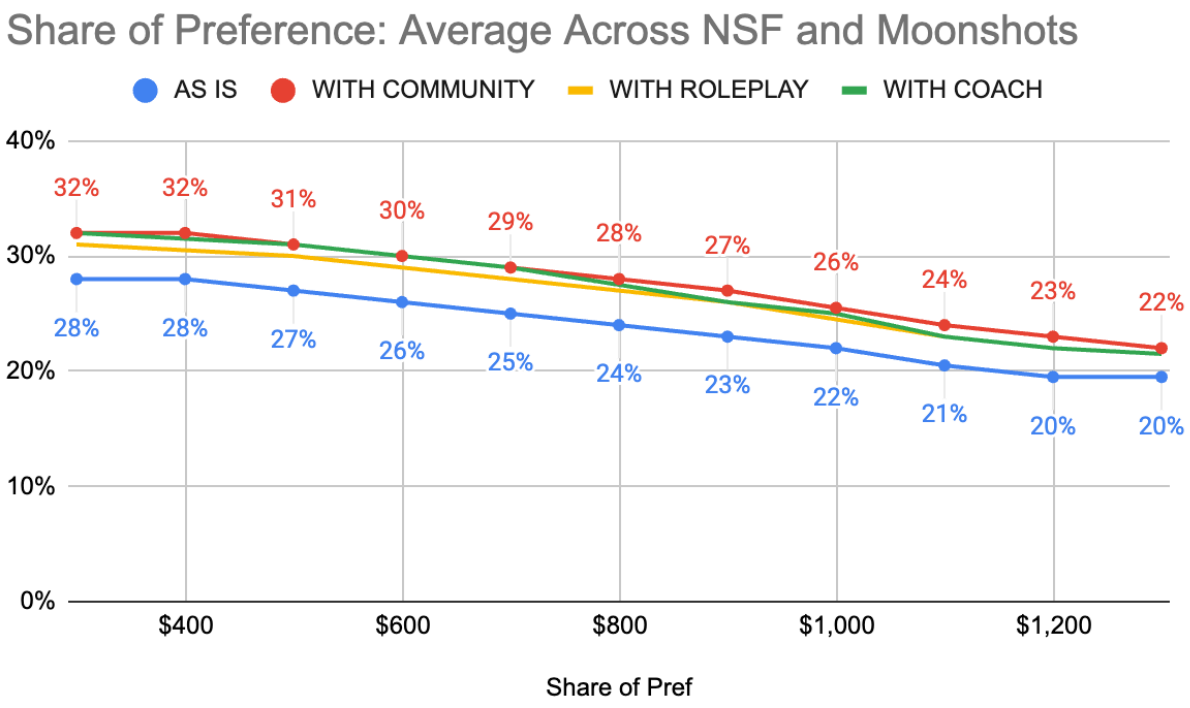
1. Control $299 vs. Variant 1 $599 vs. Variant 2 $799: New Single Tier (as shown in screenshot above)
    a. For the control option (new single tier), preference is at 27% for NSF and 29% for Moonshots
    b. When moving up to $599, each drop just 2pp to 25% for NSF and 27% for Moonshots
    c. This data signals that we can test up to $799 before we see slowing revenue growth
    d. ⇒ In order to test the curve, we recommend testing $599 and

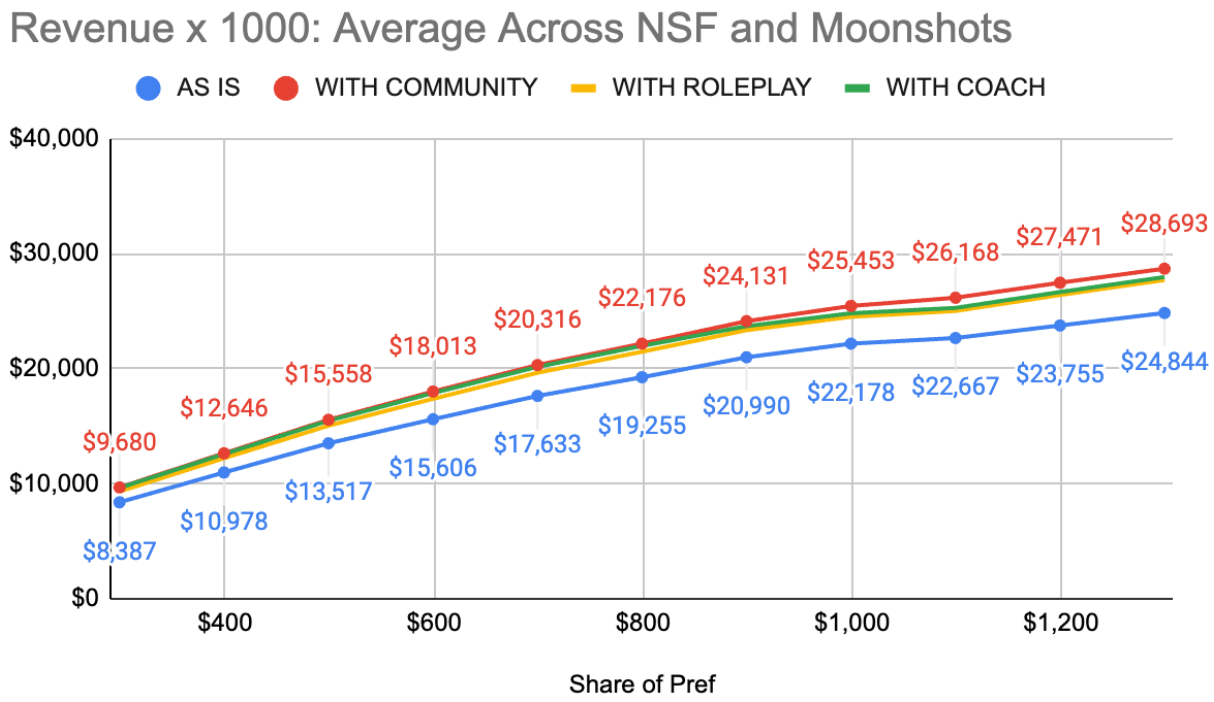



2. Variants: Single Tier + Community OR Role Play OR Coaching
    a. Adding any of the three options on top of the control increases preference

b. Averaged across all price points, Community drives the most additional preference as well as the most additional revenue
c. At the $599 price point, Community and Coach drive equal amounts of additional revenue (+15%); roleplay drives less (+11%)
d. With Community and with Coach, the data signals that we can test up to $699 before we see slowing preference and revenue






3. Thought Starter Variants: Single Tier + AI TA OR Monthly Live Office Hours
    a. A couple of thought starters if we bring in Expert Access options: AI TA OR Monthly Live Office Hours
    b. Both of these options drive higher preference lift than community, role play, or coaching
    c. Worth considering testing AI TA if easier to execute than office hours or community, given we have a version in Core

| Increase in Preference vs. Control | WITH COMMUNITY | WITH ROLEPLAY | WITH COACH | WITH AI TA | WITH LIVE MONTHLY OFFICE HOURS |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **$299** | 14% | 11% | 14% | 18% | 16% |
| **$599** | 15% | 12% | 15% | 17% | 17% |
| **Avg. across price points** | 16% | 11% | 14% | 18% | 17% |

| Increase in Revenue x 100 vs. Control | WITH COMMUNITY | WITH ROLEPLAY | WITH COACH | WITH AI TA | WITH LIVE MONTHLY OFFICE |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|

| | | | | | HOURS |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **$299** | 15% | 11% | 15% | 18% | 17% |
| **$599** | 15% | 11% | 15% | 18% | 17% |
| **Avg. across price points** | 15% | 11% | 13% | 17% | 16% |